the reduced stature as a matter of exigency. Several of his loyalists have even joined the saffron party, reinforcing the image of Amarinder doing the playmaker's job as a floater on the left wing, so to speak, for the national party.

The game won't be easy. For one, there's the curious fact that Amarinder is going in as an Opposition leader who has to bear the burden of anti-incumbency, having been booted out as CM—amidst much low drama—as recently as mid-September. Not to speak of his reputation as a reclusive administrator who ran his regime from his farmhouse in the outskirts of Chandigarh, mostly via a coterie. But both he and the BJP—and the third partner, Sukhdev Dhindsa's Shiromani Akali Dal (Sanyukt), which is contesting 17 seats—are banking on a blend of symbolism and synergy on the ground. Punjab's electoral field, historically bipolar, is also unusually crowded this time, a fact they hope to play to their advantage.

Out of the PLC's 37 battle sites, 26 are in the Malwa region, concentrated around the erstwhile Phulkian Estate, homebase of the Patiala fiefdom, of which he is the titular maharaja. Malwa has 69 seats and most will see multi-cornered contests. A traditional Akali stronghold, the Aam Aadmi Party had made noticeable gains here after 2014. The farm agitation was most furious in this region too; the farm unions are serious competitors this time. Winning against such odds would be as much a question of luck, of a favourable turn on voting day, as anything else.

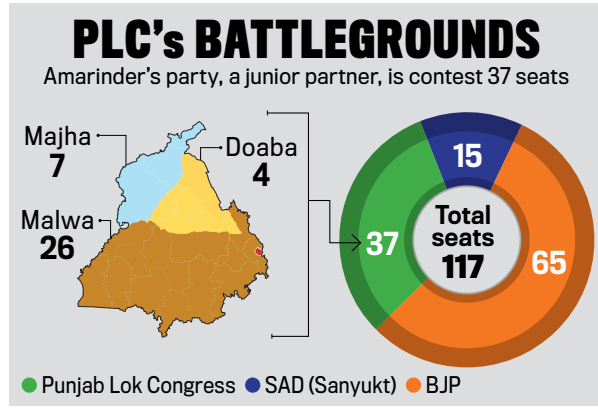
But more than electoral gains, the BJP is hoping the alliance with the 80-year-old former CM will open doors to newer territories. This includes fishing in the unquiet waters of Sikh politics. Amarinder is perhaps uniquely placed here as a facilitator. For, the ex-Congressman is also an ex-Akali man, who has had quite an eclectic political journey. The PLC is Amarinder's fourth party. After starting with the Congress circa 1980, brought in by his Doon School mate Rajiv Gandhi, he quit after Operation Blue Star and shifted to the Akali Dal. His next 14 years were spent on that side of the spectrum—for a brief while, he even floated his own Sikh hardline outfit, the Akali Dal (Panthic). Though he rejoined the Congress in 1998, becoming the alpha and omega of the state unit for over two decades, he knows the vocabulary of Sikh politics quite well. That's why a BJP leader says, "Amarinder will be one of the many helping hands for the BJP to understand those nuances."

Amarinder is also balancing that with some choice symbolism on the nationalist side—riffing on national security, the threat of militancy and drug trafficking. Perhaps ironic for a leader whose old images from a gurudwara in Dixie, Canada, had the brass-lettered words 'Khalistan Zindabad' written prominently in the background. Yet, as a man who often boasts of his three years in the Indian army's Sikh regiment, he's always comfortable in nationalistic fabric. He has, in fact, been taking potshots at state Congress chief Navjot Sidhu, claiming that in 2019, Pakistan prime minister Imran Khan had approached him through a common contact to have Sidhu reinducted in the cabinet.

Punjab's electorate has an often under-acknowledged presence—Hindus, 38.5 per cent of the state's population, and they are either in majority or dominate the results in 45 seats. The BJP is contesting 30 of them, but 10 are with PLC. That, along with the moderate Sikh base Amarinder himself nurtured during his long years as Congress CM, will form the primary catchment zone for the alliance. Amarinder is playing to that gallery, speaking of Punjab's "hard-earned peace" and saying the alliance has come together for the sake of national security. Whether incidents like the sacrilege at a Kali temple in Patiala will galvanise that part of the landscape, and help paper over the alliance's weak cadre base, remains to be seen. ■



ANI



Graphic by ASIT ROY